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**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Southern Africa

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**Section Title(S):** Marriage • The Joking Relationship

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In the genealogies of about 175 !Kung of the Nyae Nyae region there is no instance of marriage among any of the above-mentioned relatives. However, we heard of two first-cousin marriages among some distant !Kung.

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Norms

582

Regulation Of Marriage

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A !Kung must not marry a person who has the same name as his parent. In the two instances we know where this rule was broken the people lied, admitting it only after someone else told us about it. A man must not marry a woman to whom he applies the term */utsu* (this seems to be regarded as a particularly stringent prohibition), nor may a woman marry a man she terms *≠tum*. We know a man who broke this rule. His marriage with his */utsu* caused a scandal which was still reverberating after two years.

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Norms

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Naming

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Regulation Of Marriage

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Sex And Marital Offenses

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The preferred marriage among !Kung is with a non-consanguineous name-relative whom ego terms *!gu!na* (or *tun!ga* w.s.) or *tũn* m.s. SiHu and HuBr are both termed *tun!ga* w.s. and BrWi and WiSi are termed *tũn* m.s. These are considered desirable marriages, especially the sororate, but neither the sororate nor the levirate is obligatory.

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Regulation Of Marriage

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Secondary Marriages

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Marriages with persons termed *!umba* or *!undai* are not forbidden. Persons who use the terms *tsu* and *//ga* for each other may marry unless one has the name of the other's parent. Persons who use the sibling terms may marry. These marriages, though not forbidden, are not preferred.

582  
Regulation Of Marriage

There is no category of persons with whom sexual intercourse is permitted by !Kung custom except the spouse. If illicit sexual intercourse is indulged in, it is carefully concealed.

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Extramarital Sex  
Relations

### *The Joking Relationship*

The joking relationship is an important element in !Kung culture. It is in the foreground of people's minds. The !Kung never once mentioned the generational aspect of their kin terminology system but whenever kinship matters were discussed they spoke of the joking relationship. The !Kung do not train their children to know the precise genealogical position of collaterals,<sup>1</sup> but they teach them the term to use and the joking status of the term. Sometimes an informant would not know whether, for instance, a relative he termed *tsu* was his FaBr, his MoBr or who, but would say that his parents taught him to use that term for the relative and that he must not joke with him.

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Kinship Terminology

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Kin Relationships

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Transmission Of  
Cultural Norms

The joking relationship creates a dichotomy which divides consanguineous kin, affines, and name-relatives into two groups. Every kinship term is associated with a joking status and the culture either allows ego to joke or prohibits him from joking with every person to whom he applies a kinship term.

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Kinship Terminology

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Kin Relationships

<sup>1</sup> As to lineal kin, all our informants knew the precise genealogical position and names of their grandparents and grandchildren but many did not know the names of their great-grandparents. (We did not meet any !Kung who had a great-grandchild.)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ [hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs: ✉ [hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



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